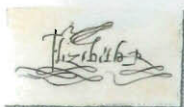


ELIZABETH I



FOR 45 YEARS from 1558–1603, a truly remarkable woman governed England. By force of personality and political skill, Queen Elizabeth I united her divided country and presided over a glorious period in the arts and culture. Yet she had to struggle all her life: her mother died when she was only three, her half-sister, Mary, put her in prison and, as an adult, she was a single woman in a world dominated by men. But Elizabeth overcame every adversity, and when she died in 1603, she left England one of the most prosperous and powerful nations in Europe.



Elizabeth I's accession to the throne, at the age of 25

Early life

Elizabeth was the daughter of Henry VIII (r.1509–47) and his second wife, Anne Boleyn. She was born in Greenwich Palace on 7 September, 1533. Elizabeth's mother was executed for treason when Elizabeth was just three years old. The future queen was imprisoned briefly while her Catholic half-sister Mary was crowned queen. Elizabeth took the throne on 17 November, 1558, after Mary's death.

Church and State

Elizabeth's father Henry VIII broke with the Roman Catholic Church in 1534, establishing the Protestant Church of England. Her half-sister Mary I (r.1553–58) tried to return England to Catholicism, but Elizabeth introduced the Anglican faith, as a compromise between Catholicism and extreme Protestantism.



William Cecil

Cecil, later Lord Burghley, served Elizabeth first as her Chief Secretary of State and, after 1572, as Lord Treasurer. He introduced many reforms and was an able adviser to the queen. He died in 1598, and his son became chief minister.



Mary, Queen of Scots

Mary was Elizabeth's heir, but also a Catholic. She became the centre of plots against Elizabeth, notably one led by Mary's page Anthony Babington. Elizabeth reluctantly had Mary tried and executed for treason in 1587.

Spanish Armada

As leader of Catholic Europe, Philip II of Spain, husband of Elizabeth's half-sister Mary, was a threat to Protestant England and encouraged plots against the queen. After the execution of Mary, Queen of Scots, Philip decided to invade England. In 1588, he sent a huge Armada of 130 ships carrying 20,000 soldiers. Harried by English ships, attacked in the English Channel, and wrecked by severe storms, the Armada was forced to return, in defeat, to Spain.



English fire ships are sent to meet the Spanish fleet.

Spanish ships escape towards the North.

Francis Drake

Between 1577 and 1580, in his ship the *Golden Hind*, Francis Drake became the first Englishman to sail around the world. He delayed preparations for the Spanish Armada by attacking the fleet while it was at anchor in Cadiz Harbour in 1587, and played an important part in its defeat the following year. He continued to attack Spanish shipping until his death off the coast of Panama in 1596.



Phoenix emblem

Elizabeth created a strong public image of herself by adopting the phoenix as her emblem. The "Phoenix Jewel", dated around 1574, shows a bust of Elizabeth, with a reverse image of the mythical phoenix rising from flames.



The famous "Phoenix Jewel"

Virgin Queen

Elizabeth spent her life surrounded by suitors, yet she never married. Powerful foreign monarchs courted Elizabeth throughout her life, eager for a stake in her flourishing kingdom, but she played her suitors off against each other for political gains. Elizabeth gloried in her role as the Virgin Queen, using it to create a national self-confidence that fuelled a flowering of the arts, distinguished by William Shakespeare, the poet Edmund Spenser, and composers such as Thomas Tallis.

Elizabeth stands on a map of her kingdom.



ELIZABETH I

- 1533 Born in Greenwich Palace near London, England.
- 1536 Elizabeth's mother, Anne Boleyn, executed for treason.
- 1554 Elizabeth put under house arrest by half-sister, Mary.
- 1558 Succeeds to the throne; appoints William Cecil as Secretary of State and Matthew Parker as Archbishop of Canterbury.
- 1559 Act of Supremacy makes her head of Anglican Church.
- 1588 Spanish Armada defeated.
- 1603 Dies in Richmond Palace.

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